

Believe Everything You Hear!



A new breed of speakers out there is bringing out the audiophile in every one of us. Which one will *you* buy?

Varun Dubey

Hot: “5.1”. Not: “300 W PMPO”! Gone are the days when the typical home or personal sound setup consisted of a home-made Videocon or Philips mini stereo system. Also gone are the days when we were satisfied with the sound that those systems delivered. We want—in fact, demand—good speakers these days.

For a wholesome aural experience when listening to music, playing a DVD or screeching off the start line when playing *NFS Underground2*, you need a sound system that does not just drum out the beats, but enhances the listening experience by putting you smack in the middle of the action!

The problem, of course, is that there’s such a range out there—and they are all good—that apart from word of mouth, we have very little to go by when we decide to get a good speaker set. Hence this comparison.

Read on and find out which one of these aural delights will satisfy your craving for the ultimate audio experience!

A Nomenclature Primer

First off, what does ‘2.1’ or ‘4.1’ mean? This nomenclature denotes the number of satellites and subwoofers. So in a 4.1, you would have four satellite speakers and one subwoofer. Similarly, in a 5.1, you would have five satellites—three in front of you and two behind you—along with a subwoofer.

Two’s Company (2.1)

Because the prices of 5.1 and 4.1 speaker sets are tumbling, irrespective of VAT, we decided to compare only the absolute top of the line 2.1 sets available. So we had the Creative Mega Works THX 250D, Harman/Kardon Soundsticks II, JBL Creature II, and of course, the Bose Companion 3.

The feature list here wasn’t exactly exhaustive, with JBL and Harman/Kardon not even bothering to put in remotes. The Bose Companion 3 comes with a wired

circular remote that lets you adjust the volume and also mute the output. The Creative remote had the most features, it let us control volume and bass, and also had a power button.

Compared to the Bose set, the build quality of the Creative speakers was just OK—nothing you would hang in an art gallery, but sturdy. The JBL Creature II speakers looked like something straight out of *Independence Day*, and were built with material that looked rather cheap, especially the chrome plating.

The Harman/Kardons were made of glass. The construction quality was really good, and we thought the speakers were neat!

Looks and build quality apart, what really matters, of course, is how these babies perform—so we put them through their paces one by one.

Let The Tests Begin!

We started with our bass and treble tests, where the king and



Harman Kardon Soundsticks II (2.1)

How We Tested

Our test PC was an AMD Athlon 64 FX 53 with 1 GB of Corsair dual-channel DDR RAM. The sound card was a Creative Audigy 2 Platinum, and the hard disk, a 120 GB SATA.

We put the speakers through an exhaustive test process, including multiple music-specific tests, a Game Test, and of course, a Movie Test.

The Game Test consisted of running the d3_c17_12 demo—a benchmark—with all the audio settings set to maximum quality. For the DVD Movie Test, we used the *Fast and Furious* clip from our DTS sampler.

The DTS sampler disk is a widely-used disk for demonstrating home theatre system capabilities. It contains very high-quality songs and movie clips in 5.1 surround sound format.

On the music front, the process was divided into CD Audio, MP3 and DVD Audio. The CD and MP3 tests were further divided into English and Hindi, which were then divided into instrumental tracks and vocal-specific tracks.

The DVD audio was rated on bass, treble, and vocal reproduction based on a DTS sampler disk. The songs we used were Eric Clapton’s *Broken Hearted* and Sheila Nicholas’s *Faith*.

For the English Audio CD Test, the vocal-specific track we used was *I’m Ready* by Bryan Adams; this was chosen because there is very little electronic equipment used in the song, and was performed live. The instrumental track we used was *Sadness I* by Enigma, because of the variety of instruments the song uses.

In the Hindi Audio CD test, we used a rendition by Pandit Bhimsen Joshi for the vocals, and Pandit Ravi Shankar’s *Sitar* recital for the instrumental test.

In the MP3 test, the tests were performed just as above, with Dido’s *Don’t Leave Home* being used for the English vocals and *Sadness I* by Enigma for the instrumental music test.

In the Hindi Music test, we used the song *Mitwa* from *Lagaan*, and Strings’ *Anjaane Kyon* for the vocals and instrumental tests respectively. All MP3 files were encoded at 192 Kbps.

Apart from these, we also tested the speakers by playing specific frequency files, from as low a range as 30 Hz all the way to 15 KHz.

We then specifically tested the bass and treble strengths of the audio systems at various volume levels using THX-certified bass and treble files.